

You said it...



We do not deserve the pride of being open



I want to convey an aggressive message to all of you.

I think that there is something wrong. I see that you people criticise non-open projects (mostly operating systems) like Windows too much. I think that is not being fair to the computing culture.

I've used many OSs—right from Windows 95 to Windows 7 (and every other Windows release in between), SUSE 9.1 to openSUSE 11.2 (and almost all the distros I get from magazines like LFY), BSDs, and recently I used a Mac OS as well. I am a power user of both Linux and Windows.

I am not a fan boy. It's just that I like to keep it simple, straightforward, clear and free from prejudices. I have done my experiments with Slackware and had created my own distro using LFS. I like tweaking things manually, whether they are the .conf files in Linux or the registry of Windows. I like Linux more than any other OS. I do a lot of things on my Windows machine and much more on the Linux box—from simple download management to Web serving and FTP serving on my simple network.

But in my humble opinion, companies like Apple, Sun and Oracle push the standards to a higher level (yes, I too agree Microsoft and innovation are not related in any way). Closed source software is also good, unless we are really able to prove that open source is more powerful, which I think we are not doing. There are things made in closed rooms that are better than their open source counterparts. For example, MS Office 2007 introduced that fabulous user interface, while OpenOffice.org 3 looks quite plain. Forget the interface; OOo has yet to implement something as basic as a grammar check in word processing.

How about gaming? Why isn't there any good framework for game development? Is it possible to encrypt that one single file on disk in Linux, with as much ease as in NTFS + Windows? The GIMP cannot compete with Photoshop. It has a cluttered interface and no one fixes that.

I have 3D support for Windows Vista in VMware Workstation. Yet, VirtualBox is still not up to it. Now if you say that VMware should open up their 3D support to the world, I have two questions:

1. Why should they? They developed it with a lot of hard work and they want a profit. And to be fair to those who worked hard for it, well, they deserve the profit.
2. Why can't we develop something on our own? Why do we need to ask them to open their source code?

All I want to say is: yes, it's great to be proud of the openness we have. But I think that the pride we take in openness need not be accompanied with the undue criticism we make of the Apples and Microsofts of the world. We seem to forget that there is a lot that still

needs to be done to raise standards within the open world. Our criticism does not help us, while their work does help them.

Let's create something new and refine the way we think about openness. It's us, the open source community that is lagging behind; and it's because of our mistakes. We are deluding ourselves if we think that we are doing great, because there is a whole lot that still needs to be done and no one is doing it!

—Vaibhav Kaushal, vaibhavkaushal123@gmail.com

ED: Thank you Vaibhav, for sharing your insight. Discussions like these are always essential. And we'd definitely like to hear more from all our readers about the concerns raised by Vaibhav. [Note: We've had to edit the above feedback because it was too lengthy—but we believe we've reproduced the most pressing concerns.]

Linux success story



We are a central government office and early in 2007 we switched over completely to Linux. We have RHEL 5 on our server, and the desktops either have RHEL 4 or Fedora 11. We have more than 50 desktops connected to the server. The PCs dual boot between Windows XP and Linux, but that's only to satisfy the whims of those visiting our office.

We had some disgruntled employees when we switched over, literally overnight, to Linux, but there was not a single case of anyone coming forward to say that he/she could not use Linux for the usual office work, which is essentially office applications (word processing, spreadsheet and presentations) and Internet browsing. For those who couldn't really live without their MP3 collections, our IT personnel installed the necessary codecs for them.

The upside is that since switching over to Linux, we have not had a single day of disruption on our network, either due to a system problem, malware or a virus attack! Despite this, I still find it difficult to convince the other offices in my department to switch over completely to Linux. Is this just resistance to change?

I have noticed that some organisations that provide e-services to the public have locked themselves to MS products, which is rather infuriating. An example is the Web banking solution of the Bank of India. It runs only on IE. How can a commercial entity like a bank be so lacking in insight as to do this? How are people with OSs other than Windows supposed to access their Web banking account?

I am also looking for a solution to connect my cell phone to Linux and sync the contacts, notes, calendar,